Haligric Research Integration Series

REIKI

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Japanese Art of Hands-On Energy Healing — Origins, Practice, and the Modern Debate Over Its Power

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A century ago, a man fasting on a sacred mountain in Japan is said to have received a method for channeling healing energy through the hands. What began as one teacher's quiet practice traveled through a Christian orphanage founder, a naval physician's clinic, and a Hawaiian-Japanese widow's suitcase across the Pacific — emerging, decades later, as one of the most recognized names in complementary healing.

Reiki asks its practitioners to believe in something unproven and unfalsifiable: that life force can be felt, directed, and shared through the palms. Millions of people, including nurses and hospice workers inside major hospitals, have found something in the practice worth keeping. Mainstream science, so far, has found little it can measure.

This is the story of Reiki — where it came from, what its practitioners believe and do, and why it remains one of the most quietly contested healing traditions in the world.

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Origins — Mikao Usui and the Birth of a Practice

Reiki traces its origin to Mikao Usui (1865–1926), a Japanese lay Buddhist and spiritual seeker who lived through the rapid modernization of the Meiji and Taisho eras. Usui was, by most accounts, a well-traveled and well-read man — accounts differ on the specifics of his education and prior occupations, and much of the biographical detail available in English-language Reiki literature is drawn from oral tradition passed down through his students rather than from contemporaneous documentation, so dates and details vary between sources.

The most widely repeated origin story holds that in March 1922, Usui undertook a twenty-one-day period of fasting and meditation on Mount Kurama, a sacred site north of Kyoto associated with esoteric Buddhist practice. At the end of this retreat, tradition says, he experienced a profound spiritual awakening in which he received both the ability to channel healing energy through his hands and an understanding of the symbols and method that would become Reiki. Whether this is understood literally, symbolically, or as a later hagiographic embellishment depends on the school of Reiki one studies — but nearly every lineage traces its authority back to this account.

Shortly afterward, in April 1922, Usui founded the Usui Reiki Ryoho Gakkai ("Usui Reiki Healing Method Society") in Tokyo, the organization generally credited as the first formal Reiki teaching body. He taught in Tokyo and, following the catastrophic Great Kanto earthquake of 1923 — during which he and his students reportedly treated large numbers of injured survivors — his practice grew substantially. Usui died in 1926; the society he founded continued in Japan under his senior students, and (unusually among the founder-successor organizations of new Japanese spiritual movements) the Usui Reiki Ryoho Gakkai still exists in Japan today, though it has historically kept a low public profile and its teachings differ in some respects from the Reiki taught in the West.

The word "Reiki" itself is a compound of two Japanese characters: rei (霊), often translated as "spirit," "soul," or "mysterious/sacred," and ki (気), the vital life-force energy found throughout Japanese and Chinese traditional thought (cognate with Chinese qi). Taken together, "Reiki" is usually rendered in English as "spiritually guided life force energy" or "universal life energy."

Key Figures and the Lineage to the West

Mikao Usui (1865–1926)

The founder of Reiki, discussed above. Usui is remembered in Reiki tradition primarily through the accounts of his students, since he left comparatively little in the way of personal writing that has survived and been translated. A memorial stone erected by his students at Saihoji Temple in Tokyo remains an important primary source for biographical claims about him.

Chujiro Hayashi (1880–1940)

A retired Japanese naval officer and physician, Hayashi became one of Usui's senior students and is credited with systematizing Usui's teaching into a more structured clinical form, including the sequence of hand positions widely taught today. Hayashi opened the Hayashi Reiki Kenkyukai clinic in Tokyo, where multiple practitioners would treat a single patient simultaneously, and kept detailed treatment records. It was at this clinic that Hawayo Takata received treatment and later trained.

Hawayo Takata (1900–1980)

A Hawaiian-born woman of Japanese descent, Takata traveled to Japan in the 1930s while seeking treatment for serious health problems and encountered Reiki at Hayashi's clinic. After her own recovery, she trained under Hayashi and, in 1938, brought Reiki back to Hawaii, becoming the practice's principal conduit to the Western world. Over the following decades Takata taught Reiki throughout the United States and Canada, initiating twenty-two Reiki Masters before her death in 1980. Nearly every Western Reiki lineage today — Usui Shiki Ryoho, and the many styles descended from it — traces its authority back through Takata.

After Takata

Following Takata's death, her granddaughter Phyllis Lei Furumoto and other of Takata's Master-level students continued teaching and organizing the practice, notably through The Reiki Alliance. Other Takata-lineage students, including William Lee Rand, founded independent organizations — Rand's International Center for Reiki Training (ICRT) is among the largest Reiki training and certification bodies in the world today. Numerous branch styles have since emerged, including Radiance Technique, Raku Kei Reiki, Karuna Reiki, and Holy Fire Reiki, each adding or modifying elements while retaining the core Usui framework.

Key Texts

Because Usui himself left little formal published writing, "Reiki texts" in the Western sense are mostly manuals produced by later teachers to standardize instruction: Takata's own hand-copied manual (used to train her students), Hayashi's clinical treatment record ledgers, and the modern training manuals distributed by organizations such as the ICRT and The Reiki Alliance. The Gokai — Usui's Five Precepts, discussed below — is the closest thing Reiki has to core scripture, and it is traditionally recited rather than read as literature.

Theology and Belief — Ki, the Five Precepts, and the Symbols

Ki and Universal Life Force

Central to Reiki belief is the concept of ki — an unseen vital energy believed to flow through and animate all living things, closely related to the Chinese concept of qi found in Traditional Chinese Medicine and the prana of Indian yogic traditions. Reiki practitioners hold that illness, fatigue, and emotional distress arise, at least in part, from disruption or depletion of this life force, and that a trained practitioner can act as a channel through

which "universal" ki — sometimes described as coming from a divine or cosmic source rather than the practitioner's own body — flows into the recipient to restore balance. This is a belief claim rather than a measured physical phenomenon: no instrument has been shown to reliably detect ki, and its existence is not accepted within mainstream biomedical science.

The Five Reiki Precepts (Gokai)

Usui is said to have taught a short set of ethical precepts meant to be recited daily, understood as inseparable from the physical practice of Reiki — healing of the spirit and conduct alongside healing of the body. Versions vary slightly in translation, but the commonly taught form is:

- Just for today, do not anger.
- Just for today, do not worry.
- Honor your parents, teachers, and elders.
- Earn your living honestly.
- Show gratitude to every living thing.

These precepts are typically framed as "just for today" — a deliberately achievable, present-focused ethical discipline rather than a lifelong vow, reflecting influence from Japanese Buddhist and Shinto ethical thought.

The Symbols

Traditional Usui Reiki includes a small number of sacred symbols, drawn and visualized (and in the original teaching tradition, kept confidential and revealed only at the corresponding training level) to focus or direct energy for particular purposes. The best known are Cho Ku Rei (associated with amplifying energy and "power"), Sei He Ki (associated with emotional and mental healing), Hon Sha Ze Sho Nen (associated with distance healing, transcending time and space), and, at the Master level, the Dai Ko Myo (regarded as the master symbol, associated with spiritual transformation). Historically these symbols were treated as an oral, initiatory secret transmitted only from teacher to student; the rise of the internet and of published Reiki manuals in the late twentieth century made them widely public, which remains a point of some tension within more traditionalist branches of the practice.

Ceremonies and Practice — Attunement and the Reiki Session

The Attunement (Reiju)

Entry into Reiki practice is traditionally marked by an attunement — in the Japanese tradition of Usui's own society, called reiju, meaning roughly "spiritual offering" or "blessing." In Western Reiki lineages descended from Takata, the attunement (sometimes called "initiation" or "empowerment") is performed by a Reiki Master and is understood to open or tune the student's energetic channel, enabling them to act as a conduit for Reiki energy going forward. The ceremony is generally brief — a matter of minutes — and typically involves the Master using specific hand placements, breath, and the sacred symbols in a prescribed sequence around the student, who sits with eyes closed in a receptive,

meditative state. Traditional teaching holds that, once received, a Reiki attunement is permanent and does not need to be repeated, though many students undergo attunements again at each new level of training.

A Typical Hands-On Reiki Session

A full Reiki treatment session, whether given to another person or performed as self-treatment, generally follows a recognizable structure:

- The recipient lies down (or sits) fully clothed, usually on a treatment table, and is invited to relax and breathe naturally.
- The practitioner centers themselves briefly — often with a short meditation or an intention to "become a clear channel" — before beginning.
- The practitioner places their hands lightly on or just above the recipient's body in a sequence of standardized positions, typically beginning at the head and moving down through the torso to the limbs. Hayashi's original clinical sequence covered roughly a dozen positions; many modern practitioners use a shortened set focused on the head, shoulders, and torso.
- Each hand position is generally held for three to five minutes, or until the practitioner senses the energy flow at that location has "completed" — sensations commonly described include warmth, tingling, or a pulsing feeling in the hands.
- A full session typically runs 45 to 90 minutes; the practitioner may close with a few minutes of hands resting near the feet, said to help "ground" the recipient, and a brief closing gesture of gratitude.

Distance (or "remote") Reiki is also widely practiced, in which the practitioner uses the Hon Sha Ze Sho Nen symbol and a period of focused intention to direct Reiki toward a recipient who is not physically present — a practice with no accepted physical mechanism in conventional science but one that is a standard part of Reiki II training in most lineages.

Self-Care and Daily Practice

Reiki is unusual among energy-healing modalities in placing heavy emphasis on self-treatment: once attuned, practitioners are typically encouraged to use Reiki on themselves daily, not only as a wellness routine but as an ongoing practice of the Five Precepts.

Self-Treatment Routine

A standard self-treatment mirrors the hands-on session described above, adapted to positions the practitioner can reach on their own body — typically the eyes and temples, the back and sides of the head, the throat, the heart and chest, the solar plexus and abdomen, and the knees or feet. Many practitioners build this into a morning or evening ritual lasting fifteen to thirty minutes, often paired with a few minutes of quiet meditation and a recitation of the Five Precepts.

Meditation and Mindfulness

Beyond hands-on self-treatment, Reiki practice commonly includes short meditative techniques associated with specific lineages — such as Hatsurei-ho, a Japanese-style Reiki

meditation involving breathing, energy cleansing, and a technique called "kenyoku" (dry bathing) used to clear residual energy before and after treating others.

Everyday Use

Practitioners frequently describe using brief, informal Reiki — a few minutes of hands-on-self or a quick visualized symbol — for situational stress, before difficult conversations, before sleep, or on a sore area of the body, treating it less as a formal therapy and more as an integrated daily habit, similar to how some people use prayer or brief meditation throughout the day.

Cosmology, Institutions, and the Wider Energy-Healing World

Levels of Training

Most Western Reiki lineages teach in a three (or four) tier structure:

- Reiki I (First Degree): the student receives their first attunement and learns hand positions for self- and hands-on treatment of others; the emphasis is on personal healing and physical-level practice.
- Reiki II (Second Degree): the student is taught the traditional symbols (Cho Ku Rei, Sei He Ki, Hon Sha Ze Sho Nen), enabling distance healing and generally considered the level at which a practitioner may begin treating others professionally.
- Reiki III / Master (sometimes split into Master Practitioner and Master Teacher levels): the student receives the Dai Ko Myo symbol and, in the Teacher tier, is trained to perform attunements and train new students themselves, becoming part of the ongoing lineage.

Relationship to Other Traditions

Reiki sits within a broader family of hands-on and energy-based healing traditions worldwide, though it is generally treated as a distinct, Japanese-originated system rather than a direct descendant of any one of them. Points of comparison and influence commonly noted include Traditional Chinese Medicine's concept of qi and qigong practice, therapeutic touch (an American nursing-derived practice developed independently in the 1970s), and the broader New Age and "energy medicine" movement of the late twentieth century, into which Reiki was frequently absorbed and marketed alongside crystal healing, chakra work, and similar modalities — an association traditionalist Reiki teachers sometimes resist, preferring to frame Reiki as a discrete lineage-based practice rather than a generic New Age modality.

Institutions and Certifying Bodies

Reiki has no single global governing body or agreed international accreditation standard — a frequent point of criticism (see Controversies, below). Notable organizations include The Reiki Alliance (founded by Takata-lineage Masters, including her granddaughter Phyllis Lei Furumoto, and associated with a more traditionalist approach), the International Center for Reiki Training (ICRT, founded by William Lee Rand, one of the largest training and certification networks), the International Association of Reiki Professionals (IARP), and the

UK's Reiki Council/UK Reiki Federation. In Japan, the original Usui Reiki Ryoho Gakkai continues to exist, generally teaching a form closer to the original method and remaining largely separate from Western Reiki organizations. Individual certification requirements, hours of training, and fees vary considerably between organizations and even between individual teachers.

SELC Reiki — A Contemporary Lineage

Among the many branch styles Reiki has produced since Takata's students began adapting it, one is taught by this series' own producer: SELC Reiki — "Subtle Energy Light Code Reiki" — offered through I.Q. Productionz (Inner Quality Productionz) under its Entertainment & Metaphysical Health programming. Like other branch lineages, SELC Reiki accepts the standard Reiki lineage account: rei as universal, ki as life force (with variant names for the same concept across cultures), and the practice's traceable origin with Usui — so that, in this teaching, all Reiki is understood as fundamentally "Usui Reiki" at root, with generations of practitioners and teachers since adapting it intuitively.

Light Codes in Place of the Traditional Symbols

SELC Reiki's central departure from most Western Usui-descended lineages is in its attunements. Rather than transmitting attunement primarily through the traditional Japanese symbols (Cho Ku Rei, Sei He Ki, Hon Sha Ze Sho Nen, and Dai Ko Myo), SELC Reiki uses what it calls "light codes," established through a slower, individualized attunement process. The traditional symbols are still taught within SELC Reiki, but attunement to them is offered by request only rather than as a default part of training. The rationale given for this departure is twofold: the historical origin of the traditional symbols in early-twentieth-century Japan, and a teaching that "new connections" are needed for what the program describes as humanity's "upgraded consciousness," intended to help practitioners "break the patterns of our history."

GPAC and Energetic Hygiene

SELC Reiki sessions are structured around an energetic-hygiene model called GPAC, developed by Geraldine Orozco (bayareameditation.com). Each session works to clear layers of subconscious "baggage" that the client is ready to release, resting on the premise — shared with other energy-healing traditions in this document — that disease begins in the subtle body before it manifests physically.

Course Structure and Rates

I.Q. Productionz offers SELC Reiki in a session and three-level structure:

- SELC Reiki Virtual Healing Session — 30 minutes and up — $74.99
- Learn SELC Reiki Level 1 — basic energetic hygiene and self-healing work, plus 55 light code attunements delivered over the course of a year — $999.99
- Learn SELC Reiki Level 2 — breathing, visualization, frequency, internal meridian cosmic orbit, and Qi Gong techniques, plus 44 additional light code attunements — $555.55

- Become a SELC Reiki Master — techniques to individualize practice, how to teach and give attunements, receiving unique light codes, and managing a SELC Reiki business — $444.44

The SELC Affirmative Principles (PHHC)

SELC Reiki's foundational ethical framework — analogous in function to Usui's Five Precepts, though distinct in content and form — is a set of four affirmations known by the acronym PHHC: Peace, Humility, Honesty, and Compassion. Each carries its own set of sub-affirmations worked with in practice:

- PEACE — "I am at peace": My energy is peaceful. My soul is peaceful. My spirit is peaceful. My mind is peaceful. My body is peaceful. "I am at peace."
- HUMBLE — "I am humble": I know my truth. I know my worth. I am patient. I trust the process. I listen fully. "I am humble."
- HONEST — "I am honest": I know how I feel. I express my feelings. "I am honest."
- COMPASSIONATE — "I am compassionate": I see everyone as worthy. I value all lives. "I am compassionate."

These four affirmations are taught as the foundation the rest of SELC Reiki practice is built on; Level 1 training includes dissecting each one individually and developing a personal process for achieving it. The program illustrates their necessity with a hockey metaphor — without a puck, there cannot be a goal, let alone a game — describing PHHC as what "solidifies" the practice in the same way.

Legacy and Influence

From its transmission to the West by Hawayo Takata in 1938, Reiki has grown into one of the most widely recognized names in complementary and alternative medicine (CAM). Surveys of CAM use in the United States conducted by federal health agencies have found that hundreds of thousands to low millions of American adults report having used Reiki or a similar energy-healing therapy, and practitioner-training organizations estimate that a substantial number of people worldwide — commonly cited (by Reiki organizations themselves) in the range of a million or more — have received at least a Level I attunement.

Reiki's most notable institutional inroad has been into hospital and hospice settings. Since the 1990s and 2000s, a growing number of U.S. hospitals — including major academic medical centers — have incorporated Reiki into integrative-medicine or supportive-care programs, typically offered by trained volunteers or staff to patients before surgery, during chemotherapy, or in end-of-life and hospice care, generally framed as a complement to (never a replacement for) conventional medical treatment, aimed at reducing anxiety and promoting relaxation and a sense of comfort. Some U.S. nursing schools and continuing-education programs for nurses offer Reiki training, and a number of academic medical centers list Reiki among their integrative-medicine offerings.

In popular culture, Reiki has become broadly recognizable — referenced in wellness media, films, and television, and taught widely through yoga studios, spas, and independent practitioners — to the point that "Reiki" is one of the few energy-healing terms recognized by a general audience even among people unfamiliar with its specific practices or history.

Controversies and the Scientific Debate

Reiki occupies a genuinely contested space between complementary-care practice and pseudoscience, and a fair treatment of the tradition requires presenting both what its practitioners and patients report and what the scientific literature has — and has not — found.

The Case for Skepticism

Mainstream science and medicine have not found a validated physical mechanism by which Reiki could work. Ki/life-force energy has never been detected or measured by any instrument in a way accepted by physics or biology, and organizations such as the American Cancer Society and the UK's National Health Service note that no scientific evidence demonstrates Reiki can cure disease. Systematic reviews of Reiki clinical trials (including reviews published in journals such as the International Journal of Clinical Practice and analyses summarized by outlets like Science-Based Medicine) have generally found the existing research base to be small, frequently poorly controlled, prone to bias, and inconsistent in outcomes — with many of the more positive results attributable to inadequate blinding (a real difficulty in energy-healing trials, since it's hard to design a convincing sham treatment) or to the placebo effect, expectation, and the simple relaxation of quiet touch and rest. Skeptic organizations, including the Committee for Skeptical Inquiry and outlets like Science-Based Medicine, class Reiki as pseudoscience, and some hospital ethicists have raised concerns about offering unproven therapies under a medical institution's umbrella, arguing it can lend false credibility.

The Case Practitioners and Patients Make

Practitioners and many hospital integrative-care programs draw a careful distinction: Reiki is generally offered as a complementary, not curative, therapy — intended to reduce stress, anxiety, and the perceived burden of pain or illness, not to treat disease itself — and note that patient-reported outcomes in hospital settings (reduced anxiety before surgery, improved reported comfort in hospice care, patient and family satisfaction) are consistently positive even where the underlying mechanism is unproven. A smaller body of published research, including some randomized trials examining pain and anxiety reduction, has reported statistically significant benefits over no-treatment or waitlist controls, though far fewer studies show Reiki outperforming a well-matched placebo/sham-Reiki control. Patients and practitioners frequently report that the quiet touch, attention, and dedicated time of a session provide genuine comfort and a felt sense of relaxation, benefits some researchers attribute to relaxation response and human contact rather than to a unique energetic mechanism — but which are nonetheless real to those who experience them.

A Fair Summary

The most defensible position, and the one this document takes, is this: there is no accepted scientific evidence that Reiki transmits a measurable energy or cures disease, and it should never be used as a substitute for evidence-based medical care. At the same time, many people who receive Reiki — including in serious clinical settings such as oncology and hospice wards — report a genuine sense of comfort, reduced anxiety, and improved well-

being, benefits that appear to be real even when their mechanism is best explained by relaxation, attention, ritual, and the placebo response rather than the direct transfer of a life-force energy. Both of these things can be true simultaneously, and most careful writing on Reiki — from hospital integrative-medicine departments to skeptic organizations alike — holds both at once.

Continuing Your Journey

This document has traced Reiki from Mikao Usui's mountain retreat in 1922 through Hayashi's Tokyo clinic and Hawayo Takata's journey across the Pacific, to the attunements, symbols, and daily self-practice that define the tradition today — and to the genuine, unresolved debate over what, scientifically, it is actually doing.

For those wishing to move from understanding to practice, structured instruction in Reiki — including SELC Reiki, the light-code-based lineage detailed above — is available through I.Q. Productionz.com; see the Rates and Learn sections of the site for current course details.

Closing Reflection

Whatever one concludes about the nature of ki, Reiki endures because it offers something simple and old-fashioned in a fast and clinical world: a quiet room, an attentive pair of hands, and permission to rest. That, at minimum, is not nothing — and it may be the truest thing Reiki has to teach.